

Methods — what wins now, and what this production adds

The first table is current best practice on the platform, as used by strong entrants and documented in the bible. The two boxed methods are this production's additions — one better than practice, one best available. Both were adversarially reviewed before they were written down; their qualifications are part of the method.

Image-first anchor string	decide the film as ~39 stills before any video; motion animates decisions already made
End→start frame chaining	shot N's last frame is N+1's literal first — continuity by construction, drift watched per link
Forward extension	feed the finished clip back in and continue the take (+30s) — the oner engine, 720p tax paid at finish
Multi-shot in one generation	several angles inside one generation hold world, wardrobe and light constant across their own cuts
Ramps and body wipes	speed ramps and near-black wipes deliver a cut's accent without leaving the frame
Motion control	drive a still character with a reference clip — choreography becomes repeatable instead of rerolled
Cheap-pass previz + promotion	every shot at budget tier first; any draft frame that beats its anchor is promoted into the ledger
Deflicker → upscale → grade	in that order, always — the reverse bakes shimmer into the master permanently

BETTER

The sketch-lock loop

1. Compose on the printed 21:9 frames (sheets 04–08) until silhouette, camera height and light direction are decided. Draw inside the frame — a photo of an unframed sketch silently re-centres when a model crops it.
2. Photograph the winner (bible → Paper → notes camera). From then on the sketch is the shot's **judging target**: every batch is selected against the drawing; a re-roll that drifts is rejected on sight. Zero rules risk — nothing external enters the project.
3. Prompt-only first. Escalate to sketch-as-reference only for stubborn layout (shot size, figure placement, the two match-cut pairs) after ~two failed batches — via the multi-reference image lane (nano_banana_pro) to build a photoreal comp draft. Never in the soul_2 lane: its one reference slot belongs to the lighting plate.
4. When a sketch goes in: “framing, shot size and figure placement only; render photoreal; match the movement plate; no graphite, no monochrome, no paper texture.” Sketch bleed is a hard reject. Confirm on the rules page that hand-drawn reference inputs are permitted — every input publishes with the history.

***Qualifications:** claims precision, never credit savings — free iteration already exists on unlimited-trial models. A drawing states a composition a prompt cannot; the discipline is that the sketch stays a target by default.*

Paper wins when a composition is easier to draw than to describe — stubborn framing, matched cuts, exact figure placement — and the sketch stays a target, not an upload.

BEST

The re-anchor budget

1. Classify every join at string time: **designed anchor** (drift resets), **inherited frame** (pixel-exact start, drift-from-design accrues), or **authored bridge** (near-black or blinding — drift absorbed).
2. **Never more than two consecutive inherited joins.** A third means promote the join to a designed anchor, or spend a bridge. This film's longest runs — S6–S8 and S10–S12 — are exactly two links; the budget makes the accident a law.
3. Inherit **start frames only** — starts inherit pixel-exactly, end frames land approximately on every chainable model. Never chain onto an extracted end frame.
4. Between resets, sub-chains are independent: strict order lives inside a sub-chain, so S6–S8, S10–S12 and the standalones can generate in parallel.
5. At Gate D, measure each draft's landing against its designed end anchor; promote better frames in inheritance order only.

***Reviewed and rejected on the way here:** building a long chain from both ends toward a designed midpoint — it relocates error rather than halving it, and forces earlier shots to end on extracted frames, trading exact inheritance for approximate. The budget generalises what bridge B01 already does at S11→S12.*